

Changing “master and slave” terminology in robotic-assisted technologies



To the Editor:

The recently published editorial in *Gastrointestinal Endoscopy*, “Will robots take over our jobs as endoscopists?” comments on the important role that robotic-assisted technologies may have in the future of endoscopy.¹ The authors describe shared characteristics of novel robot-assisted endoscopic platforms, the first of which involves a “master and slave” platform. Although the “master and slave” terminology was used by the originators of the technique,² we believe that this language is unacceptable and should be changed.

The word “master” has been used in other industries but is being eliminated. In real estate, for instance, the term “master bedroom” had been used for decades. Since the summer of 2020, after the murder of George Floyd, there has been a remarkable change in vernacular.³ The real estate industry now uses words like “primary” or “main” to refer to the largest bedroom in the house. We believe that medical terminology should adopt similar changes.

In medicine, we have the responsibility to promote the health and wellness of the people in our community; part of that means dismantling racism. We must acknowledge and address the impact of institutional racism on the patients we care for. And we must examine our own forms of institutional racism and implicit bias that have an impact on patient care and outcomes. Inclusive language represents a small but important piece of this mission. Therefore, we hope that the authors and editors at *Gastrointestinal Endoscopy* will transition away from “master” and “slave” terminology to language that is more inclusive and neutral.

DISCLOSURE

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Response:



I would like to thank Deutsch-Link et al¹ for pointing out issues in our article² on using the “master and slave” terms that may not be apparent to all endoscopists. In respect to robotic technologies, I believe it may be less of an issue to use the terms because we are not dealing with human subjects here, and the term is actually used in engineering to describe a particular type of robotic design.³ Nevertheless, we agree that *Gastrointestinal Endoscopy* should use terms that are more inclusive and neutral.

DISCLOSURE

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